

Top 10 Reasons People Leave the Church

By Thom Rainer

Why did you leave the church?

Why did you decide not to go back to a church, any church?

These and other questions are among those we have been asking for many years through a variety of research projects. Why do people leave the church and not return? We have specifically asked those questions of the formerly churchd who were active in a church for at least two consecutive years, but did not return for at least two more years.

Here are the ten most common reasons people leave the church and don't return.

1. "I got out of the habit." They had no major impetus that prompted them to leave. They became less and less active in the church until they were inactive.

2. "I left after I graduated from high school." Many of them went to college and did not attend church during those years. Others simply left church after getting out of their parents' home.

3. "I decided I didn't like the institutional church." We are hearing that reason a lot. But we can't get a consistent answer on why they are anti-institutional. And we hear a number of different definitions of "institutions."

4. "I was hurt at the church." For certain, there are a lot of wounded former church members out there. The local church can be pretty mean. It can be painful for a church member who gets on the wrong side of a church bully or a petty argument.

5. "I just couldn't find a church to meet my needs." This person is the classic church hopper and shopper. They practice consumer and preferential Christianity with vigor. But, alas, when none of the 28 churches they visited met their needs, they decided to stop trying altogether.

6. "I had a need and the church didn't meet it." This reason is related to number five with some specificity. The former church member is referring to a specific incident where the church was not there for him or her. Just two weeks ago, I spoke to someone who did not feel the church was there sufficiently after the death of her mother.

7. "I never felt connected in the church." Almost every church member who offers this reason did not get involved with a group in the church. Such is the reason I am obnoxiously redundant about connecting members to groups.

8. "I did not give to the church." Of course, we really didn't hear that statement from a former church member. But I have encouraged pastors to ask the person who has visibility to giving records to find out if the now inactive church member was a giver. Most of the time, the answer is no. One pastor asked the question about four families who left the church in a specific year. The total giving of the four families was zero.

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9. "I left when Pastor John left." A number of the formerly churched were loyal primarily to a specific pastor. So, when that pastor left the church, they became inactive.

10. "We moved and never went back to church." This issue is worthy of a future study. How many of the formerly churched relocated and never connected with a church? Why did they take this path?

Why People Leave Churches: The Top 10 Reasons (And How to Find a Better Fit)

By FaithScout Team

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Every year, roughly 3,000 churches in the United States close their doors permanently. But behind that statistic is a quieter, more personal trend: millions of individuals quietly stepping away from churches they once attended regularly. According to Gallup, church membership in the U.S. dropped below 50% for the first time in 2020 and has continued to decline. If you've left a church — or you're thinking about it — you're far from alone, and your reasons are probably more common than you think.

This guide walks through the ten most common reasons people leave churches, drawn from surveys by Barna Group, Lifeway Research, and the Pew Research Center, as well as thousands of real stories shared by churchgoers. More importantly, it offers practical advice for what comes next — because leaving a church doesn't have to mean giving up on finding one that actually fits.

1. Feeling Unwelcome or Like an Outsider

This is the one that surprises church leaders but not the people who've lived it. A 2023 Lifeway Research study found that 42% of people who stopped attending church cited feeling like they didn't belong or weren't welcomed. That's not necessarily about rude greeters or empty parking lots — it's about the difference between a friendly handshake at the door and actually being folded into the life of the congregation.

What this looks like in practice: You show up for three months straight and nobody learns your name. The small groups are full of people who've known each other for 15 years, and there's no natural entry point. After the service, everyone talks to their friends, and you walk to your car alone. It's not hostility. It's indifference, and it's the number one reason first-time visitors never become members.

What to do about it: Before you write off all churches, recognize that welcome culture varies enormously from congregation to congregation — and even between campuses of the same church. When evaluating a new church, pay attention to what happens after the greeting at the door. Do people invite you to coffee? Does anyone follow up during the week? Use FaithScout's church search to read visitor reviews that specifically mention hospitality and newcomer experience — those details tell you more than any church website will.

2. Disagreement With Teaching or Theology

Theological misalignment is the second most common reason people leave, and it comes in two flavors. Sometimes a person's beliefs evolve over time, and they gradually realize they no longer agree with their church's stance on key issues. Other times, a church itself shifts direction — a new pastor arrives with a different theological emphasis, or the denomination takes a position that feels wrong.

Pew Research data shows that 23% of people who leave a church do so because of disagreements over social or political issues that the church has woven into its teaching. Another 18% cite doctrinal differences around topics like the role of women in leadership, views on LGBTQ+ inclusion, the interpretation of Scripture, or stances on salvation and grace.

What to do about it: Be honest with yourself about what you actually believe and what's negotiable versus non-negotiable. Not every theological difference is a dealbreaker — but some are, and pretending otherwise just delays the inevitable. When searching for a new church, look past the denomination label. A "Baptist" church in Portland may look nothing like a "Baptist" church in rural Alabama. Try FaithScout's church matching quiz — it asks about your theological priorities and matches you with congregations that actually align with where you are now, not where you were ten years ago.

3. Hypocrisy or a Judgmental Culture

Barna Group's research has consistently found that "judgmental" is one of the top three words unchurched Americans use to describe Christians. But this reason isn't just cited by outsiders looking in — it's one of the top reasons insiders walk out.

This shows up in specific, concrete ways: the congregation that preaches generosity but spends 85% of its budget on a building renovation. The church that talks about grace on Sunday but gossips about the single mom in the fellowship hall on Monday. The leadership that demands accountability from members but refuses transparency about its own finances or decision-making.

A 2019 Barna study found that 51% of churchgoers have personally witnessed behavior in their church that they would describe as hypocritical. That's a staggering number, and it erodes trust faster than almost anything else.

What to do about it: No church is free of imperfect people — that's the whole point. But there's a difference between a congregation that acknowledges its imperfections and one that pretends they don't exist. Look for churches that practice financial transparency (published budgets, third-party audits), have clear accountability structures for leadership, and create space for honest conversation rather than performative perfection. Reading detailed visitor reviews on FaithScout can help you spot these patterns before you invest months attending.

4. Life Changes and Relocation

This is the most straightforward reason and, according to Lifeway Research, accounts for about 34% of church departures. People move for work, for school, for family. The Census Bureau reports that roughly 27 million Americans move each year, and for churchgoers, relocation almost always means starting the church search process from scratch.

The problem isn't the move itself — it's the friction of finding a new church in an unfamiliar area. Many people intend to find a new church after moving but never do. A Barna study found that 30% of churchgoers who relocate haven't found a new church home even a year later. The Sunday routine breaks, other commitments fill the gap, and inertia takes over.

What to do about it: Don't wait. Research shows that the longer you go without attending a church after a move, the less likely you are to resume. Start your search before you move. Use FaithScout's search by location to explore churches in your new city, read reviews, and even plan your first visit before your furniture arrives. Having a plan makes the transition dramatically easier.

5. Burnout From Overcommitment

Churches run on volunteers, and the most dedicated members often bear a disproportionate load. The 80/20 rule applies ruthlessly in church life: roughly 20% of the congregation does 80% of the serving, giving, and organizing. If you're in that 20%, burnout isn't a possibility — it's an inevitability if boundaries aren't in place.

What makes church burnout particularly painful is the guilt layer. Saying "no" to a church request can feel like saying "no" to God, especially in congregations where busyness is equated with faithfulness. The volunteer who teaches Sunday school, leads a small group, serves on the welcome team, and sings in the choir isn't just tired — they're drowning, and the culture often doesn't give them permission to come up for air.

What to do about it: If you're burned out, leaving entirely might not be the answer — stepping back might be. A good church will respect your boundaries and welcome you even when you're not serving. If your church can't handle you simply sitting in a pew for a season, that tells you something important about the culture. When evaluating new churches, ask directly: "What does involvement look like here? Is there pressure to volunteer immediately?" Churches that respect the difference between an invitation and an expectation tend to be healthier places long-term.

6. Leadership Failures or Scandals

A pastor's moral failure, financial misconduct, or abuse scandal doesn't just hurt the individuals directly involved — it sends shockwaves through the entire congregation. The Hartford Institute for Religion Research has documented that pastoral misconduct is a factor in approximately 25% of church closures. For the people in the pews, the damage goes beyond disappointment. It can feel like a betrayal of everything the church was supposed to represent.

The aftermath is often handled badly, which compounds the pain. Cover-ups, blame-shifting, pressure on victims to "forgive and move on," and refusal to involve outside accountability — these responses drive out not just the directly affected individuals but also the principled members who can see that the institution is protecting itself rather than its people.

What to do about it: If you've been hurt by a leadership failure, give yourself permission to grieve. You haven't lost your faith — you've lost trust in a specific institution, and that's a legitimate wound. When you're ready to look again, prioritize churches with strong governance structures: an independent board of elders or deacons, external denominational accountability, published financial statements, and clear policies for reporting misconduct. These structural safeguards aren't glamorous, but they're the difference between a church that's accountable and one that's just charismatic.

7. Worship Style Mismatch

This one seems superficial until you live it. Worship style isn't just about musical preference — it shapes the entire atmosphere of a Sunday morning. The person who connects with God through quiet reflection, hymns, and liturgy is going to feel genuinely disconnected in a church with a fog machine, concert lighting, and a 30-minute set from a rock band. And vice versa.

A 2021 Barna survey found that worship style was a "very important" factor for 67% of churchgoers when choosing a church, making it the second most important factor after preaching quality. Yet people often minimize this, feeling shallow for caring about music or aesthetics. It's not shallow. How you worship affects whether you actually engage or just sit through it.

What to do about it: Know yourself. If you've sat through months of services feeling like a spectator rather than a participant, the worship style might not be right for you — and that's okay. Use FaithScout's church comparison tool to see worship style descriptions side-by-side. Better yet, take the matching quiz and let it surface churches whose style aligns with how you actually connect. Many churches post recordings of their services online, so you can preview before you visit.

8. Lack of Depth in Teaching

"I felt like I was hearing the same three sermons on repeat." This complaint comes up constantly, especially among long-time churchgoers. After years of attending, some people feel like the teaching never goes deeper than surface-level encouragement or self-help talks wrapped in Bible verses.

Lifeway Research found that 36% of people who stopped attending church cited preaching quality as a significant factor. This isn't about wanting seminary-level lectures every Sunday. It's about wanting teaching that challenges you, that wrestles honestly with difficult texts, that applies Scripture to real-world complexity rather than reducing everything to three-point platitudes.

Conversely, some people leave because the teaching is too academic — long on Greek word studies and systematic theology but short on practical application and emotional connection. Neither extreme serves people well.

What to do about it: Listen to a few sermons from any church you're considering. Most churches post these on their website or YouTube channel. Ask yourself: Does this pastor engage with the text honestly, including the parts that are hard or uncomfortable? Is there an invitation to think, or just to agree? FaithScout's church profiles include ratings on teaching quality from real visitors, which can help you filter churches that match the depth you're looking for.

9. Painful Personal Experiences

Sometimes the reason isn't systemic — it's personal. A painful divorce where the church took sides. A mental health crisis that was met with "just pray harder" instead of real support. A child who came out as gay and was shunned. A death in the family where the casseroles stopped after two weeks but the grief went on for years. These experiences leave scars that make walking back into any church building feel impossible.

The Pew Research Center found that 20% of former churchgoers cite a specific negative experience as their primary reason for leaving. These aren't people who drifted away — they were pushed out by how a real crisis in their life was handled by the people who were supposed to be there for them.

What to do about it: If this is you, your pain is valid and your caution is understandable. You don't owe any church a second chance. But if you do want to try again eventually, start small. Attend without committing. Sit in the back. Don't share your story until you've had time to observe how the church treats people in difficult situations. Look at how they talk about mental health, divorce, doubt, and suffering — not just in sermons, but in their small groups and support ministries. A church that can hold space for mess and uncertainty is worth a second look.

10. Schedule and Logistics

This is the least dramatic reason but one of the most common, especially post-2020. Work schedules, long commutes, kids' sports leagues on Sunday mornings, health issues that make regular attendance difficult — life logistics push church attendance to the margins for millions of people.

The American Time Use Survey shows that Americans' leisure time has been squeezed by roughly 30 minutes per day compared to 2010. Sunday isn't the protected "church day" it was a generation ago. Many people work weekends, and the competition for Sunday morning time — youth sports alone is now a \$28 billion industry — is fierce.

What to do about it: Look for churches that offer multiple service times, including Saturday evenings and weekday options. Many churches also offer high-quality online services that let you stay connected when you can't be there physically. When searching on FaithScout, check service times listed on church profiles. A church that only offers one 10 AM Sunday service is great if that works for your schedule — but if it doesn't, there's no reason to force it when other options exist.

Pew: Why some Americans—including Catholics—leave their childhood faith
by Gina Christian - OSV News
December 16, 2025

Empty pews are seen in a file photo at St. Gabriel Catholic Church in Washington. A new study from Pew Research Center released Dec. 15, 2025, looks at the various reasons why Americans, including Catholics, leave their faiths -- with most who exit their childhood religious traditions doing so by age 30. Credit: OSV News photo/Tyler Orsburn

(OSV News) — Americans who leave their childhood religion typically do so by the age of 30, with just under half saying they stopped believing their former religion's teachings.

For Catholics, retention rates tend to be significantly lower than for other faiths, while former Catholics cite varying reasons for leaving the church, depending upon their current religious affiliation — or lack thereof.

And on balance, having positive childhood experiences of religion and growing up with regular religious practices both play a significant role in adult retention of childhood religious identity.

Those were among the findings released Dec. 15 by Pew Research Center in a report titled "Why Do Some Americans Leave Their Religion While Others Stay?"

Pew drew on data from a May 5-11 survey of 8,937 U.S. adults who are part of the center's American Trends Panel and from the center's 2023-2024 Religious Landscape Study, representing 36,908 U.S. adults.

Overall, slightly more than half (56%) of U.S. adults still identify with their childhood religion, with 35% reporting they have "moved on from the religion of their youth," said Pew.

Another 9% "weren't raised in a religion and still don't have one today," said the report.

Pew found that retention rates for Catholics (57%) — who comprise 19% of U.S. adults — were much lower than those for Hindus (82%), Muslims (77%), Jews (76%) and Protestants (70%), although somewhat higher than for Latter-day Saints (54%) and Buddhists (45%).

In addition, said Pew, "14% of Americans raised Catholic are now Protestant," representing 4% of all U.S. adults. Pew's Religious Landscape Study found that 13% of U.S. adults are former Catholics.

Broadly, the top reason cited for leaving a childhood religion was no longer believing in the religion's teachings — with 46% of former Catholics pointing to that loss of belief for their decision to leave the faith.

Other reasons given by former Catholics for walking away were clergy and religious leader scandals (39%) and dissatisfaction with church teachings on social and political issues (37%).

Another 35% of former Catholics pointed to a gradual drifting away from their religion — slightly less than the report's overall share of 38%.

Equal shares of former Catholics said that their religion “just wasn’t important” in their lives (36%) or that their spiritual needs were not being met (36%).

Slightly more than one-quarter said they were unhappy about the way the church treated women (27%) or claimed the Catholic religion was out of date (27%).

Another 20% reported feeling called to a new faith, while 16% weren’t satisfied with their congregations and 10% said they had moved to a new community.

Just 7% of former Catholics overall attributed their leaving the faith to marrying someone from another religious tradition.

Age and political affiliation also correlate with religious retention, said Pew.

“Among adults ages 65 and older who were raised in a religion, 74% still identify with that religion, while 11% identify with a different religion than the one they were raised in, and 13% do not identify with any religion,” said the report. “On the other hand, among adults under 30, 55% still identify with their childhood religion, while 10% now identify with another religion, and 35% are not affiliated with any religion.”

For U.S. adults raised in a religion, those who identify as Republican or Republican-leaning are more likely to retain their childhood faith (73%) compared to 56% of Democrats and Democrat-leaning counterparts.

In addition, Democrats raised in a religion are “more likely to be religious ‘nones’ today” compared to their Republican counterparts, said Pew.

Respondents who left their childhood religion gave varying reasons for either embracing a new religious identity or abandoning any religious identity altogether, said Pew.

Of the former, 48% who switched to another religion said they felt “called to a new faith,” while 45% said their original religion did not meet their spiritual needs.

But 51% of those who are now “nones” — representing 29% of U.S. adults, and identifying as atheist, agnostic or “nothing in particular” — “are most likely to cite having stopped believing in the religion’s teachings as an important reason for having left their childhood religion,” said Pew.

Just over half (52%) of former Catholics who are now Protestant said their spiritual needs were not being met, with 49% reporting they felt called to a new faith.

In contrast, former Catholics who are now “nones” were much more likely to say they stopped believing in the church’s teachings (52%), compared to 34% of once-Catholic Protestants.

Former Catholics who are now Protestant were less likely than their “none” counterparts to cite the following reasons for their move:

- Clergy and religious leader scandals (30% vs. 44%)
- Dissatisfaction with church teachings on social and political issues (26% vs. 42%)
- Religion’s lack of personal importance (20% vs. 45%)
- A gradual drift away from the faith (24% vs. 41%)
- Unhappiness over the religion’s treatment of women (17% vs. 33%)
- Feeling the religion was out of date (18% vs. 32%)

A greater share of Catholics who became Protestant (16%) than former Catholics who are nones (1%) said they had married someone with a different religion.

The majority (79%) of former Catholics who now identify as Protestant said belief in the religion’s teachings was the key driver for their decision, followed closely by fulfillment of spiritual needs (76%), meaning in life (63%) and sense of community (56%).

Also cited were the religion’s teachings on social and political issues (34%), familiarity (29%), sense of religious obligation (24%), traditions (24%), family religious affiliation (17%) and lifelong congregation affiliation (4%).

Among “nones” who had been raised Catholic — a group representing 7% of U.S. adults — the majority (81%) say they have chosen not to affiliate with a religion since they “believe they can be moral” without it, said Pew.

Other common reasons for maintaining their “none” status were questioning much of religion’s teachings (67%), holding they can be spiritual without religion (57%), disliking religious organizations (53%) and distrusting religious leaders (52%).

In addition, 47% reported not having a need for religion, 33% said they did not believe in God or a higher power, and 30% noted they had bad experiences with religious people, Pew said.

Pew’s data showed that childhood experiences of religion, including attendance at services and religious practices in the home, have a demonstrable impact on adult religious identity.

In its May survey, which explored participants’ childhood religious experiences, Pew found that most lifelong Catholics (73%) reported this to be largely positive.

However, “few former Catholics” said the same, although 56% of those who are now Protestant were more likely to do so than those who are now religiously unaffiliated (26%), said Pew.

“People raised Catholic who, as adults, are either Catholic or Protestant, are generally more likely to have had a religious upbringing than people raised Catholic who are now ‘nones,’” said Pew. “For example, 84% of U.S. adults who were raised Catholic and still identify as Catholic say they grew up attending Mass at least once or twice a month, as did 77% of former Catholics who are now Protestant.”

Fewer former Catholics who are now “nones” (68%) — although well over half — report having attended Mass weekly as children.

Pew also noted that “Protestant parents are more likely than Catholic parents to say their children attend religious services at least monthly (61% vs. 47%).”

Pew detected “a similar pattern with childhood religious activities” — five in particular: saying prayers at night, making religious arts and crafts, saying grace or praying before meals, listening to religious music, and reading religious stories.

“We find that among adults who were raised Catholic, those who are still Catholic or are now Protestant are more likely to have regularly done more of these activities as children than those who are now religious ‘nones,’” said Pew.

In this regard, more Protestants (38%) than Catholics (24%) report often talking with their children about religion, “and more Protestant parents than Catholic ones describe their households as extremely or very religious (35% vs. 20%),” said Pew.

Generally, said Pew, “many U.S. parents say their children regularly participate in various religious activities, such as saying prayers at night (46%), saying grace before meals (43%), reading religious stories (43%), listening to religious music (37%), or doing religious arts and crafts (28%).

“Overall, 27% of parents say their children take part in at least four of these activities,” said the report.

Lack of religious activities in childhood, in contrast, appears to indicate that an individual will likely remain religiously unaffiliated.

“The transition from not having a religion as a child to identifying with one as an adult is relatively rare,” said Pew. “Overall, 3% of U.S. adults have made this switch.”

Those who did so cited belief in the religion’s teachings (61%), fulfillment of spiritual needs (60%) and a sense of meaning in life (55%), said Pew.

Pew: In US and other countries, Catholicism loses more members than it gains
April 27, 2026

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Attendees stand at the "Rededicate 250: A National Jubilee of Prayer, Praise and Thanksgiving" event on the National Mall in Washington on May 17, 2026. (OSV News photo/Eric Lee, Reuters)

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Why People Stay in Church and Why Others Leave, According to Pew Research

Why do some people stay rooted in their faith while others leave the church? Drawing on Pew Research, this article explores the key reasons behind church retention and deconstruction, and what church leaders can do to build trust, strengthen belief, and support long-term discipleship.

Why People Stay in Church and Why Others Leave, According to Pew Research

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Why do some people stay in church, while others leave?

This question shaped more of my life than I realized at the time, especially as I watched the friends I grew up with in church take very different paths. Some are still deeply rooted in their faith, serving and leading in their local communities. Others slipped away quietly after years of internal wrestling. And some left very loudly.

One day they were there, worshiping, volunteering, and even leading. The next, they were gone, processing their departure publicly through social media posts and comment threads.

Watching that divergence up close made the question impossible to ignore.

My own experience growing up in church was genuinely healthy. I was formed in a community that took faith and people seriously. I developed a real love for the local church, and I learned how to live with tension and imperfections without losing my footing.

And still, I watched many friends take a different path. Seeing that happen again and again made me curious about what makes the difference.

What helps someone remain rooted in faith long-term, and what causes belief to slowly unravel?

Recent research from the Pew Research Center helps bring clarity to those questions.

What the Research Shows About Religious Retention

When you are watching your friends leave their faith in real time, it can start to feel like everyone is leaving. The data tells a more complicated story.

According to a recent study entitled “Why Do Some Americans Leave Their Religion While Others Stay?”, 35% of U.S. adults have moved on from the religion of their youth, while 56% still identify with the religion they were raised in. Another 9% were not raised in a religion and still do not have one today.

Those numbers are worth sitting with. Despite the volume of deconstruction stories and public exits, a majority of people are still holding onto the faith that formed them.

So, before we talk about why people leave, it helps to start by considering why people stay.

Why Some People Stay in the Church Into Adulthood

Belief Matters More Than Habit

One of the clearest takeaways from Pew’s research is that people tend to stay when faith still feels believable and spiritually nourishing.

Among those who remain in the religion they were raised in:

64% say they stay because they believe in the teachings of their faith

61% say their faith continues to meet their spiritual needs

56% say it gives their life meaning

Community shows up too (44%), along with familiarity (39%) and tradition (39%). But those factors are secondary. The strongest reasons people stay are internal, not social. They are tied to belief, spiritual nourishment, and meaning.

Protestants Stay for Conviction and Spiritual Nourishment

That pattern is even stronger among Protestant Christians. 70% say belief in the teachings of Christianity is a key reason they stay. In other words, many Protestants are not remaining connected simply out of habit or nostalgia. They stay because Christianity still feels true to them. It still helps them make sense of the world. It still feeds their spiritual life.

What This Means for Church Leaders

For church leaders, this data offers a grounded encouragement. Trend cycles will keep changing, but the core work of sharing the truth of the gospel remains steady. People stay rooted when Scripture is taught clearly, when spiritual life is nourished, and when faith is connected to the pressures of everyday life.

None of that is flashy. But it is deeply formative. And over time, it builds the kind of resilience that does not disappear the moment church gets complicated.

And yet, people still leave.

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Why Some People Leave the Church Over Time

Age Matters

One of the clearest patterns in the data is when people tend to switch. For most Americans who change religious affiliation, it happens relatively early. In fact, 85% of those who have switched say they did so by age 30, including 46% who made that change as children or teenagers.

What is striking is that this trend holds even for older adults. Americans ages 65 and up are still much more likely to say their switch happened before 30 than later in life. For many, faith decisions are shaped early, even if the consequences unfold slowly.

Faith Erodes Gradually

When Pew asked people why they no longer identify with the religion they were raised in, most did not point to one defining event. 46% said they stopped believing the teachings of their faith. 38% said religion simply became less important in their life. Another 38% described a slow, gradual drift.

In other words, many people do not leave because something explodes – but because something fades. Their belief weakens, and faith slowly moves from the center of life to the margins.

How Trust, Politics, and Leadership Failures Shape Faith Decisions

But Pew's data also points to reasons that are not only about belief. Over one third (34%) said disagreements with social or political positions played a role. A similar number (32%) pointed to scandals involving clergy or religious leaders. And 26% said they were unhappy with the way their religion treated women. Taken together, those reasons point to a deeper issue: trust.

Political alignment shows up in the data too, though it answers a slightly different question. Among U.S. adults raised in a religion, 73% of Republicans and Republican-leaning independents still identify with their childhood faith, compared with 56% of Democrats and Democratic leaners. Democrats raised in a religion are also more likely to identify as religious “nones” today.

These numbers do not suggest that one political group is more faithful than another. They suggest that the way faith and politics intersect can influence whether the church feels credible, safe, or spiritually trustworthy.

What This Signals for Church Leaders

For church leaders, the takeaway is not “pick a side.” It is this: when faith starts to feel fused to a political identity, trust gets fragile fast. People begin to experience church less as a place to follow Jesus and more as a place to belong to a tribe.

That is why people are not only asking whether a church teaches true things. They are asking whether it deserves their trust, whether leaders handle power with integrity, and whether the church's public posture reflects the character of Jesus.

A Simple Takeaway for Pastors

If you are a church leader, you probably have names that came to mind while reading this. People you baptized. Teenagers you watched grow up. Volunteers who used to serve every week... until they stopped. Some left quietly. Some left loudly. And if you care, you still feel that absence.

And here is what the data reminds us, underneath all the statistics and percentages: your work is not wasted. Keep preaching what is true. Keep nourishing spiritual life. Keep protecting trust. Keep Jesus at the center.

Over time, that steadiness becomes a shelter for people who want to believe again.

Supporting Churches Behind the Scenes

If you want to strengthen church engagement and create more margin for discipleship, follow-up, and pastoral care, easy-to-use church management software and online giving tools from Tithely can help keep your ministry organized and connected. You can explore Tithely's tools to see how they support the behind-the-scenes work that helps people stay rooted in faith.

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Written by

Susanna Gonzales

Outreach

July 11, 2026

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Written by

Susanna Gonzales

Pew report: Why people leave, and stick with, religion

'This latest study is important because it's the first time we've asked people why they identify with their current religion,' a senior researcher says

Published: Dec 15, 2025, 7:14 p.m. MST

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Mariya Manzhos

By Mariya Manzhos

Mariya is a staff writer based in Boston who writes at the intersection of religion and culture. She is the author of the weekly State of Faith newsletter.

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Why do people stick with the faith of their childhood into adulthood, or switch to another religion? Why do some leave religion entirely?

A new report from the Pew Research Center, released Monday, examines what drives these decisions.

Most Americans today — 86% — were raised in a religious tradition and about 35% have left the religion of their childhood, according to Pew.

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"This latest study is important because it's the first time we've asked people why they identify with their current religion," Becka Alper, senior researcher at Pew Research Center and one of the report's authors, said in an email. "It also digs into why people switch religions, and about when in their life they do so."

Whether people stay or go is shaped by a web of factors, including whether they had positive experiences growing up in the faith, if they agree with its teachings and if they believe religion is necessary in their lives. One reason that repeatedly surfaced in the report is the belief that religion is not required to be spiritual.

The survey questioned nearly 8,900 U.S. adults from major religious groups, as well as the religiously unaffiliated — often called “nones,” a category that includes atheists, agnostics and those who say their religion is “nothing in particular.”

Conducted in May of this year, the survey builds on earlier data from the last 2023–24 Religious Landscape Study by Pew.

Why people stick with childhood faith

For those who remain in their childhood religion, 64% stay because they say they believe their faith’s teachings, Pew found. Many also stay because the faith fulfills their spiritual needs (61%) and it gives their lives meaning (56%) — far more than those who cite community, tradition or alignment with the religion’s political positions.

Community plays a lesser role: 44% say a sense of community keeps them connected to their childhood faith. Only 32% say alignment with political or social positions of the religion is a major reason they remain.

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In general, people who grow up religious are more likely to remain religious as adults. The same is true for those raised as “nones” — the lack of faith affiliation tends to follow people into adulthood.

Only 3% of people who were raised without a religion later adopt one in adulthood.

Belief in a religion’s core teachings remains the strongest factor in whether people stay or leave.

“One thing that’s striking is that, when we look at the reasons people give for staying in or leaving their childhood religion, a top reason for both of these is belief,” according to Alper.

The factors that encourage retention also vary by faith tradition. Protestants are especially likely to cite belief — 70% say their beliefs are why they remain in the faith. Among Catholics, 54% say their religion fulfills their spiritual needs, and fewer than half say it gives their life meaning. For Jews, tradition and community are especially important, with around 60% saying those factors keep them connected to their childhood faith.

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Although 86% of Americans were raised with a religious tradition, whether they remain religious as adults depends heavily on their childhood experiences.

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Among those who describe their religious upbringing as positive, 84% still belong to the religion they were raised in. Only 10% of this group now identify as religiously unaffiliated, and 6% have switched to another religion.

The pattern reverses for those who report negative religious experiences growing up. Nearly 7 in 10 no longer identify with any religion. Just 24% remain in their childhood faith, and 7% have adopted a different religious identity.

The level of religious practice at home also matters. Adults raised in “highly religious” households are the most likely to remain in their childhood religion, compared with those raised in households with “medium-high” (77%), “medium-low” (62%) or “low” (47%) levels of religious commitment. Pew created this scale using measures such as attendance at religious services, how often religion was discussed at home, and practices like prayer and reading religious texts.

Why people leave childhood faith

The report also sheds light on why people leave. Similarly to reasons people stick with faith, the most common reason for leaving is a loss of belief: 46% say they stopped believing in their childhood religion’s teachings. Another 38% say religion simply was not important in their lives or that they gradually drifted away.

Among those who left their childhood faith and became religiously unaffiliated, these same factors dominate — disbelief, lack of importance or gradual disengagement.

Many of the “nones” believe religion is not necessary for morality or spirituality, Pew found. And 78% of “nones” say they can be moral without religion.

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Roughly half say they dislike religious organizations or do not trust religious leaders, and 54% say they do not need religion to be spiritual.

Among those who are “nones,” nearly half say they left religion because they stopped believing in its teachings, while 44% say religion was not important in their lives.

Only a small share of “nones” believe religion is actively harmful.

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Switching religion before age 30

Not everyone who leaves abandons religion altogether. About a third of those who leave their childhood faith switch to another religion. Their reasons include disagreements with teachings, social or political views, or scandals involving religious leaders.

Among those who switched, nearly half (48%) say they felt “called to a new faith,” and a similar number say their childhood religion did not meet their spiritual needs.

Only 3% of U.S. adults were not raised in a religion but later came to identify with one.

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The report offers insight into why the previously nonreligious adults later adopt a faith. For most, the change comes down to belief: They say they believe the new religion's teachings, that it fulfills their spiritual needs and that it gives their lives meaning.

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Religious switching, as well as leaving the childhood faith, tends to happen early in life. Pew found that 85% of people who change religions — or leave the faith entirely — do so before age 30, including nearly half who made the change as children or teenagers.

Parents and religious practice

Most American parents engage in at least one religious activity with their children. Saying prayers at night is the most common practice, with 46% of parents reporting they do this regularly.

About 43% say they take their children to religious services at least once a month, and many also report activities such as saying grace before meals or listening to religious music.

These findings track with another recent study by Communio and The Human Flourishing Program at Harvard that found that frequent informal conversations with children tend to be a significant predictor of whether they maintain faith into adulthood.

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Buckets of Reasons People Are Leaving Christianity

Last updated on: April 4, 2024 at 3:11 pm by [Daniel Henderson](#)



In my last column, I wrote that we (the United States) are becoming less religious. It prompted a good deal of discussion and most of it was civil. That is one of the goals I have for this column: civil discussion about important issues.

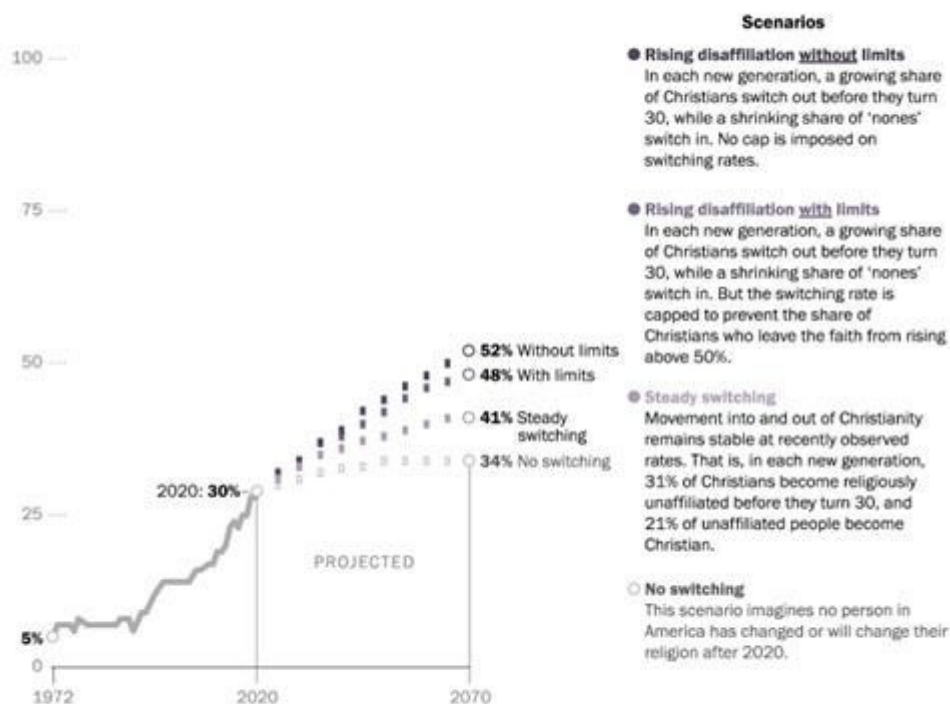
I'm following up that article with this one which will address the question of "Why." Why are people leaving their religious faith and traditions behind? It is less researched than the phenomenon of de-churching, which is plain to see.

I'll offer up **three buckets of reasons** why this is happening.

Leaving one's religious beliefs and affiliation behind is a personal decision. Each person has their unique reasons for ditching a belief system which in some cases, they've known their whole lives. So, to try and generalize too far about why millions of people in the United States have decided to do so over the past three decades may be fraught with error and oversimplification. But let's give it a try, shall we?

U.S. 'nones' will approach majority by 2070 if recent switching trends continue

% of Americans who are religiously unaffiliated



Note: Historical data describes trends among U.S. adults, based on surveys of adults. The 2020 estimate and subsequent projections show Americans of all ages. In 2020, we estimate that the religious composition of people of all ages roughly matches the adult composition. Sources: General Social Survey (1972-2006); Pew Research Center surveys (2007-2021); Pew Research Center projections (2020-2070). "Modeling the Future of Religion in America"

PEW RESEARCH CENTER

How many people are we talking about? According to a September 2022 [Pew study](#), people identifying as Christian have decreased from 90% of the U.S. population in 1972 to 64% in 2020. And in the aftermath of the COVID crisis, that number is now lower. Those identified as “none” comprise roughly 30% of the population. So, three out of ten Americans no longer identify as a Christian or “religious.”

The future for religion doesn’t look much brighter. If the current trends continue, researchers estimate that by 2070, less than 50% of the US population will still be identified as “Christian.”

Well, this certainly has ramifications in every sphere of culture, society, and our institutions. But let’s get back to the fundamental question of why.

Why are people leaving the church? Researchers are on this, and there are a few good studies that have identified dozens of reasons given

by those who have been interviewed.

Why I Left Evangelical Christianity

Since no one has interviewed me, I’ll offer a first-hand account of my decision to leave Christianity behind. It happened around 2006. My experience was a slow, gradual migration out of the evangelical circles I had lived in for over 40 years. I was “born-again” in 1964 at a Billy Graham Crusade, and until 2006, I identified as an evangelical. I taught in private Christian schools and participated in various local conservative churches as a teacher and youth sponsor.

Over the years I developed what I called, “evangelical fatigue.” It was a combination of factors that are common within evangelical communities. You had to accept other people’s religious interpretations as more valid than your own; oppose rational science; pretend to be something different than a normal human on Sundays while

attending church; learn to speak the secret language that evangelicals use; and generally, work hard to gain the approval of God, pastors, and other people. It was exhausting.

But I'll point to two major factors beyond just general evangelical fatigue with the religious system that ultimately led to my exodus out of the church. The first was the politicization of evangelical churches and the second, was a lack of empathy and concern for personal pain during a difficult time in my life.

I was confronted as early as 1980 with the sage advice that I better be voting for Ronald Reagan that year if I were a "good Christian." That was rather shocking to me since many evangelicals had voted for the Democrat, Jimmy Carter in the 1976 election, including me. Carter was the Baptist Sunday School teacher who was faithful to his wife and spoke of being born again, while Reagan was the divorced nominal Presbyterian (no disrespect to Presbyterians) who seldom attended church. Yet my faith was called into question if I supported Carter. This made no sense.

But the evangelical faith continued unabated politicization over the next 20 years with each year getting worse. By the early 2000s, evangelicals had taken over many Republican Party state and local organizations, especially in Iowa. They infused politics with a winner-take-all, apocalyptic mindset that demonized their opponents and pressured any evangelical who had a different policy position than the Republican Party. They were called RINOs. It was becoming apparent to me that the "church" was by then set on a trajectory toward pure political power at the expense of any meaningful "good news" that was related to the teachings of Jesus. In fact, by then Jesus was an afterthought, if that.

But there was another issue for me that had surfaced by the early 1990s. Politics was certainly concerning, but I faced a personal crisis in 1993 that ended up in a divorce from my first wife who was also the mother of our two children.

Divorce was an existential crisis if you were involved in any sort of Christian ministry. Instead of reaching out with care, support, and help, both my ex-wife and I were subject to judgment and dis-membership in the leadership roles we had at the time in our respective evangelical ministries. The divorce was amicable, and we tried to do what was best for our children, but the evangelicals in our lives seemed more interested in the "compromised role model" we had become. Shaming someone in distress was more important to them than loving someone in a crisis.

That event along with the disillusionment of the political motivations of evangelicals set me on a private journey of personal reflection, doubt, and questioning over the next decade or more. Those are three things evangelicals do not want you to do: think for yourself, doubt what you've been taught, and ask difficult questions. But I did, and by 2006, I became aware that I was no longer part of the evangelical community. I just couldn't do it anymore. I wasn't angry at anyone, and I didn't leave in a huff. I just in good conscience could no longer call myself an evangelical. I had moved on and finally admitted it.

I didn't realize it at the time, but I was part of a growing number of people who were experiencing a similar thing. I didn't know about the "nones" in 2006 and I didn't hear that term until much later. However, my experience has paralleled the experience of millions of others who came to terms with their evangelical mindset and found it lacking.

Another descriptive term I learned later was "deconstruction." I had deconstructed my faith but rather than leave the pieces lying around, I reconstructed something for myself that has proven to be much more rewarding, fulfilling, and satisfying. It isn't a new belief system or religion it is the opposite. It is the rejection of relying on a belief system to find connection and meaning in my life. If you want to read more about this, I will point you to my book, [Confessions of a Recovering Evangelical](#). I hope you will check it out.

The Three Buckets

The reasons people have given to researchers about why they left religion or Christianity in particular, although broad and varied, can be categorized into the three groupings that I experienced: *personal*

harm and *institutional dissatisfaction*. The third is what I will call *intellectual incongruence*. Most reasons people give can be tossed into one of these three buckets.

I will use these three categories to share what the limited research has discovered about why people leave their religious institutions. In short, these three categories tell us much about what the evangelical church has become as an institution and how it has abandoned its true calling of loving people.

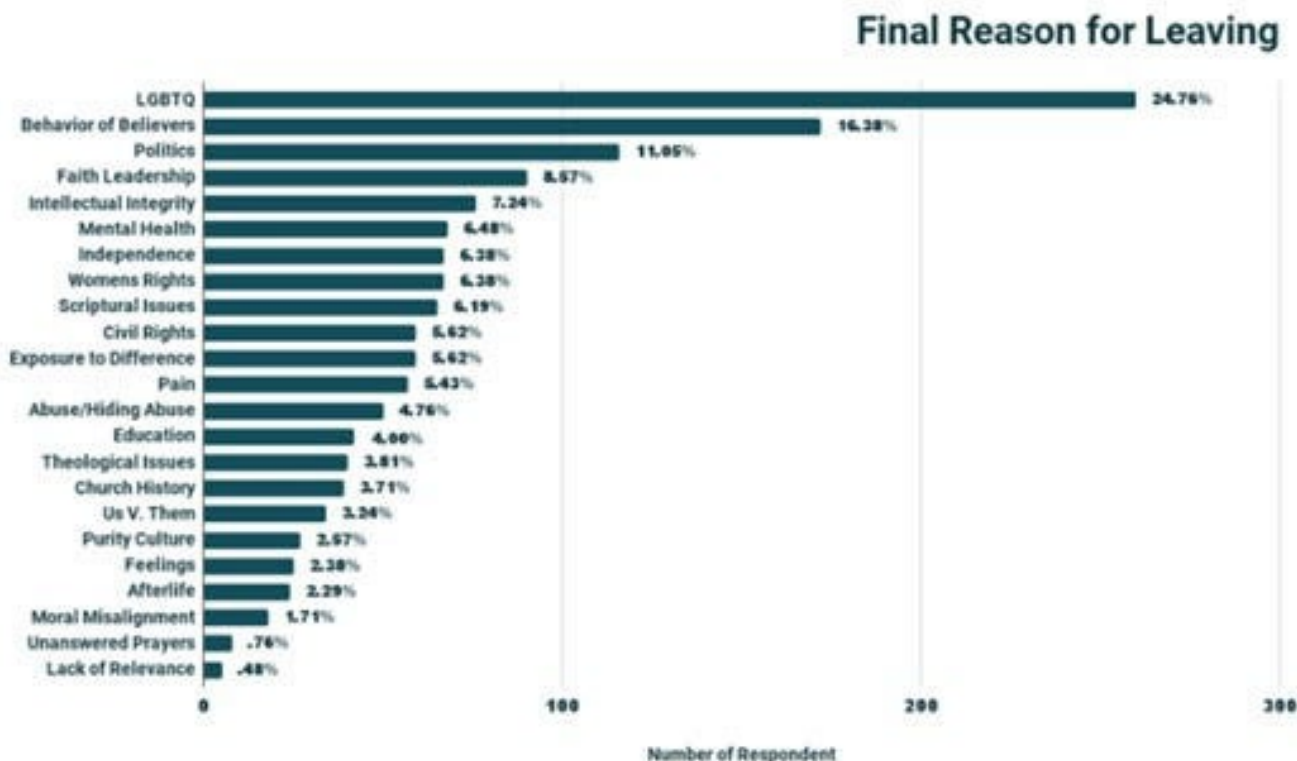
Evangelicals blame everyone else for people leaving their pews as if it were a grand conspiracy, but it comes down to what they have become as an institution and how they treat people. That's it...it isn't the libs or the Marxists or the secularists who are out to get them. If evangelicals are hemorrhaging people from their churches, it would be best for them to engage in the three things they seem to dislike most: reflection, doubt, and questioning. Something tells me they won't go there.

Bucket #1 – Institutional Dissatisfaction

One of the more insightful studies I have run across was an article by a journalist-former evangelical, Brandon Flanery in 2022. It was published in the [Baptist News Global](#) entitled, "I asked people why they're leaving Christianity, and here's what I heard." He gathered data from 1200 people asking them a series of questions about their reasons for leaving the Christian faith. Flanery created a coding system for the responses he received and was able to quantify the results. What he found was not unpredictable, but it did suspend a few myths about those who are leaving.

Those within the evangelical church are well aware of the rapid decline of church attendance especially by millennials. Their analysis and recommendations lack deep self-reflection. Instead, they blame churches for having "resorted to entertainment, performance-oriented singing groups, and shallow teaching that will not stem the exodus of the younger generations from the church." ([Answersingenesis.org](#)) The truth is much more complicated than simple stylistic or cosmetic changes.

Take a look at this graph from Flanery's study:



For many people who are leaving the evangelical faith, the institution of the evangelical church is no longer relevant. The number one issue for “leavers” is the pressure to withhold love and acceptance to a marginalized community such as LGBTQ+. It exposes the fundamental reality that the evangelical church community has failed to live up to its calling to love all people. Judging and rejecting a group of people because of how they were born is simply a deal breaker for many people, even if they are not gay.

Even the Methodist Church, one of the nation’s largest denominations, has split over this issue. In January 2023, Christianity Today reported that the Methodist Church has lost over 1800 congregations over this issue. Right here in my state of Iowa, 83 churches have split from their Methodist denomination so that they can continue to exclude some people they don’t like.

There are similar results as you look through Flanery’s list related to *women’s rights*, *civil rights*, and the *Us v. Them* mentality. As an institution or faith community, the evangelical church has become so tribal that they would rather exclude people from their fellowship and partnership instead of loving and including them. In other words, the evangelical church is so steeped in patriarchy, unconscious racism, and hate for the gay community that people are simply walking away.

Politics is high on the list too. The evangelical church as an institution, has become not just politicized but MAGAized over the past 8 years, and for many, it is another deal-breaker. As Flanery points out this is the issue that “broke the camel’s back.”

Bucket #2 – Personal Harm

The next bucket is related to personal harm, and it shows up in the results in a major way. Categories like *behavior of believers*, *pain*, *abuse*, and *mental health* all reflect the dissonance of a faith group that is called to love everyone, yet inflicts damage, harm, and even trauma on those within their congregations. This type of personal and psychological harm has given rise to a whole new area of support called “religious trauma counseling.” There are trained clinicians who help former churchgoers deal with the hurt and pain inflicted on former congregates.

You don’t have to scroll through Face Book groups very long like “Exvangelicals” or “Recovering Evangelicals” before you read personal stories from real people about how they suffered humiliation, abuse, and shame at the hands of those who claim to represent God.

Women are especially subject to this type of religious trauma which many times plays out in their marriages.

Women Outnumber Men Among the Young Adults Leaving Religion

Gender of Americans who disaffiliated from religion ...



Note: Survey of US adults (N=5,459).
Source: Survey Center on American Life, 2023.



I've heard from

more than one female “leaver” about the shame and humiliation they experienced when they went to church leaders for counsel about an abusive husband. They were told they couldn’t leave him, and they should just pray harder, be submissive, and stay in the marriage. It is a costly mistake.

The *Survey Center on American Life* has published this data about women being more likely to leave their religious faith than men, especially in Gen Z. This is a turnaround, but it isn’t surprising. Look at the graph:

I suspect this trend will continue and accelerate in the coming years.

Bucket #3 – Intellectual Incongruence

The third bucket is *intellectual incongruence*. Several categories on the graph can be placed in this bucket. *Intellectual integrity, education, theological issues*, and others reflect the problem many encounter when trying to “fit in” to a religious community at the cost of common sense, scientific methodology, and evidence. It requires the suspension of disbelief to force yourself to believe in many doctrines of the church. In an age when having vast amounts of information and counterviews in the palm of your hand, churches can no longer be the sole source of truth.

Claims of having the sole source of all truth in an “inerrant and infallible Bible” are easily contradicted by even a cursory reading. Yet, evangelicals defy logic by appealing to their highest authority even when it is nonsensical to do so. I have a chapter dedicated to this topic in my book (another shameless plug).

A personal story will help illustrate this point. At one of the last churches I attended, I was a volunteer youth sponsor. During one lively discussion session, a few of the students began to ask me questions about their church’s faith statements. They wanted to know why Christianity was the “only correct religion” while millions or even billions of others in the world worshipped a different way. They questioned the Bible as the only source of truth, and they questioned why evolution was considered wrong when it was clear to them the evidence was against creationism.

At first, I was inclined to give the same pat-apologetic answers that I had given to students for decades before. I went into defensive mode, but their sincerity and honesty overcame my need to be right. This was very close to when I decided to leave the church behind, and these students helped me see that the answers weren’t really answers. They were tired, worn-out statements of archaic ideology that simply couldn’t be defended. I eventually gave up my lame attempts to give finality and certainty to their questions and simply said, “Those are good questions...keep asking them.”

Leaving one's religious beliefs and institutions after having identified with them for so long can be a scary and difficult path. Perhaps one of the most difficult tasks is to begin to redefine who you are without the religious label, jargon, and belief statements. For me, it was learning to redefine myself in a whole new way...as a human. Just being a human with no other labels. That will be the topic of my next column...stay tuned.

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